CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

LOCKSMITH IN THE AI ERA

People lock themselves out at 3 a.m., lose every key they own, and buy smart locks they can't program. Urgency is the business model.

★ TL;DR — Median around $45K, with training in the 6–12 month band and a state locksmith license required in some states. The catch: much of the income is mobile, on-call and solo — the freedom and the 3 a.m. calls are the same package. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

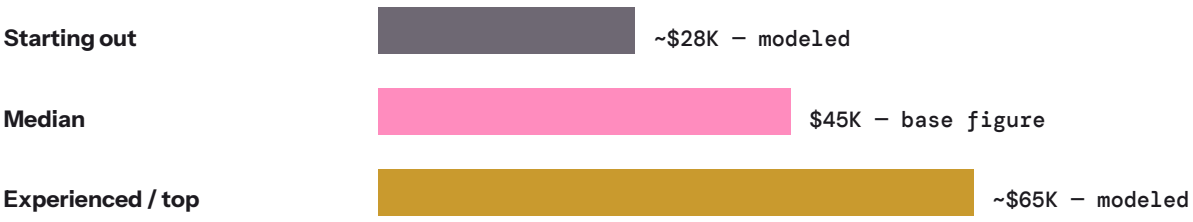
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$45K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Works because: locks, keys and access systems are everywhere, they fail and get lost constantly, and car keys alone became a high-tech, high-price market.
- Bites because: the trade attracts scammers ('$19 service call' bait), so legitimate locksmiths must out-trust as much as out-skill them.
- AI angle: minimal physically, real digitally — electronic access and automotive key programming are growing, and they're technical skills, not robot work.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Locksmith is a ~$45K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A LOCKSMITH ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Open locked homes, cars and businesses without damage — picking, bypassing, decoding
- ✓ Cut and program keys, including transponder and proximity car keys with diagnostic tools
- ✓ Install, rekey and repair locks, deadbolts, safes and commercial hardware
- ✓ Build and service access systems: keypads, smart locks, master-key systems for buildings

Think: a legal burglar with a business license and a five-star rating — the skills are the same; the paperwork and the trust are the profession.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Almost nothing of the physical work. Software helps decode keys and program fobs; it doesn't kneel at a door in the rain or drill a safe deposit box under a bank manager's eye.	Non-destructive entry is pure touch and judgment — every lock is a small puzzle with a stressed customer watching. Trust judgment matters too: verifying the person hiring you actually owns what's locked.

⚠ **Check your state first: some states license locksmiths with background checks and exams, others don't — know which game you're in. And the on-call economics are real: lockout money is night-and-weekend money.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Mobile, independent, different puzzle every call ✓ Emergency pricing: fast help at bad hours pays honestly well ✓ A classic one-person business — van, tools, phone, reputation	✗ Nights and weekends are prime time, not overtime ✗ Solo work means solo risk — verify every customer's right to enter ✗ Automotive key gear is expensive and updates constantly

Good fit? You're dexterous, patient and puzzle-happy, comfortable arriving alone to strangers' worst moments and being the calm one.
Bad fit? You need predictable hours and a team around you — or your record can't pass the background checks this trade runs on.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — APPRENTICE WITH A LOCKSMITH SHOP	DOOR B — LOCKSMITH TRAINING COURSE → MOBILE SOLO

Working under an experienced locksmith teaches what courses can't: real locks in real doors, vehicle entry on real cars, and the customer side of the job. Many shops train helpers who show mechanical aptitude and a clean record.	A structured locksmithing course (online/hybrid programs run inside the 6–12 month band) covering locks, safes, automotive and electronic access — then start mobile with lockouts, rekeys and car keys. Faster to independent, lonelier in the learning.

Smart move: Specialize in automotive keys and electronic access. Car-key replacement at a fraction of dealer prices is the trade's growth market, and commercial access systems turn one-off calls into contracts.

Where you land after: Apprentice → locksmith → automotive/access specialist → your own mobile company or a shop with commercial contracts.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
CHECK YOUR	LEARN THE	ADD AUTOMOTIVE	GET LICENSED	GO MOBILE	GROW INTO

STEP 1 — Check your state's rules first

FREE · TODAY

- Some states require a locksmith license with exam and background check; others are open. Know yours before spending anything.
- A clean record matters everywhere — shops and customers both check.

STEP 2 — Learn the core craft

6-12 MO BAND

- Lock types and functions, picking and impressioning, key machines and code cutting.
- Rekeying is the daily bread: master it until it's boring and perfect.

STEP 3 — Add automotive skills

TOOLS + TRAINING

- Transponder and proximity keys, programming tools, EEPROM basics — the modern car-key market.
- The programmers are a serious investment; buy for the car brands your market drives.

STEP 4 — Get licensed where required

STATE LICENSE · WHERE APPLICABLE

- If your state licenses locksmiths, complete the application, exam and background process before advertising solo work.
- Even where it isn't required, bonding and insurance are how legitimate pros separate from scammers.

STEP 5 — Go mobile and get reviewed

MONTHS

- Lockouts, rekeys and car keys are the mobile starter menu; answer fast, price honestly, show up in uniform.
- Reviews are the whole marketing engine in this trade — ask for them on every job.

STEP 6 — Grow into access and contracts

YEAR 1+

- Commercial work — master key systems, panic hardware, access control — pays steadier than lockouts.
- Property managers and car lots become recurring accounts, not one-off emergencies.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: check your state's locksmith licensing rules and three local shops' hiring pages.

□ Days 1–30: start a course or apprenticeship; practice locks are your new desk toys — pick, rekey, repeat.

□ Days 31–60: key machines and automotive basics; ride along on real calls if you're apprenticing.

□ Days 61–90: license application filed where required; first supervised lockouts and rekeys under your belt.

□ Day 90: in the trade with legalities handled and the high-value specialties (auto keys, access) already targeted.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ LOCKED OUT MEETS SHOWED UP. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.